

Seagram Building

In 1958, Mies van der Rohe built a 38-storey steel and glass tower in Manhattan for the Seagram distillery head office, setting new standards for modern skyscrapers. Abandoning all exterior decoration, the building is in the international style; a glossy monolith rising 157 metres (515 ft) above the granite plaza below. Often quoted as saying 'God is in the details', Mies zealously concentrated on the smallest elements of the structure, which combines a steel frame, a core of steel and reinforced concrete, and a glass skin. The frame had to be covered with fireproofing to satisfy the building code, so Mies – keen to have a structure on show – added 1,500 tonnes of non-structural bronze I-beams, which are visible through the amber-tinted glass. Mies had evolved a completely rational approach, designing 'universal' spaces enclosed in rectangular blocks, and evoking classical elements – the division into base, shaft and capital; the use of bronze – to create a sense of timeless serenity. The double-height travertine lobby and grand restaurant are designed by Philip Johnson.

